

LAW 353B – Aboriginal and Treaty Rights

Final Presentation

Submitted To: Prof. Michael Jackson

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My final project for this class is a Cree Medicine Bag. After attending the first couple classes I thought a lot about what I could make that would reflect the stories I heard in this class as well as reflect my own personal culture and traditions. From my Cree heritage I thought a project in leather goods might be a good idea. The Plains Cree from Manitoba used many different types of leather and skins to make various goods; like moccasins, medicine bags, clothes and tipis. Growing up in Manitoba, I acquired the skills to make moccasins very early. I wanted my final project to be challenging and meaningful so I decided to make a Cree Medicine Bag. I used the same skills I learnt in making moccasins: beading and leather sewing, but my Medicine Bag was much more difficult as I did not have a pattern and had to work from pictures I found of traditional Medicine Bags.

The Medicine Bag is a very spiritual and sacred object in Cree Spirituality. A Medicine Bag can vary in size and it is traditionally worn by the person to protect them spiritually, promote health and wellness and guide them down the Red Path. To reflect the stories I heard in this class I thought I would make a traditional Cree Medicine Bag filled with traditional items; like quartz, sweet grass and cedar, but also filled with items that are evidence of the contemporary reality of being First Nations.

The following is a list of the contemporary items in my Medicine Bag along with a brief explanation of their significance:

- Bottle of Ibuprofen: this item was included to reflect the current reality and pervasiveness of western medicine.
- Picture of the Nativity Scene: this item was included to show how Christianity is a huge part of life for many First Nations and Aboriginal communities. Christianity gained a stronghold in Aboriginal communities with the activities of the missionaries and the residential schools. Christianity is still the major religion of my community in Manitoba and my family.
- Picture of a Baby: this item was included to represent how the Aboriginal birth rate is significantly higher than other Canadians and in Manitoba one out of every four births is an Aboriginal baby.
- Bottle of Alcohol: this item was included to reflect the current tragedy of alcoholism among Aboriginal communities and my own family.
- Lawyer's Business Card: this item was included to represent the litigious nature of being Aboriginal today. Both the over-representation of Aboriginal people in the

Canadian criminal justice system, especially in Manitoba and the litigious nature of Aboriginal rights and title.

- Packet of Crystal Lite: this item was included to represent the over-representation of diabetes among Aboriginal communities and my own family.
- Receipt from the Bay: this item was included to reflect the historical and present consumer relationship Aboriginal people have with the Hudson's Bay Company. Despite the Bay's historical contribution to the genocide of First Nations, this company is still a viable department store. As a First Nations person I do not feel comfortable shopping at the Bay, but without many options I find myself shopping there.
- Child's paper headdress from the Tomahawk Restaurant: this item was included to represent the degradation of First Nations culture and how sacred objects within this culture have been corrupted into tacky souvenirs.
- Headdress Pin from the Assembly of Manitoba Chiefs: this pin was included to represent the currently political power and structure of the Aboriginal communities in Manitoba.

This project was a very personal for me. When I first decided to make a Cree Medicine Bag I thought the toughest part would be beading or sewing, but the most difficult part was filling it with significant items. I originally thought the contents should reflect the current reality of Aboriginal people, but the contents began to take a much more personal meaning. Many of these items reflect the challenges and issues faced by family and community, including alcoholism and diabetes. My Medicine Bag is quite literal but I feel that it has reflected my personal heritage as well as the stories I heard in this class.